# EVM-Guard: Bytecode-Level Semantic Hazard Triage and State-Falsifiable Sandbox Replay

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***Abstract*—Smart contract execution on Ethereum is irrevocable. Deployed bytecodes cannot be hot-patched, leaving protocols exposed when external calls execute before storage updates settle. Existing static linters require compiler abstract syntax trees, failing entirely on unverified on-chain bytecodes. Conversely, SMT-backed symbolic execution engines encounter combinatorial path explosion, timing out on production contracts. We introduce EVM-Guard, a bytecode-level static hazard analyzer paired with an execution-differential sandbox replay oracle. EVM-Guard recovers basic-block control-flow graphs directly from linear-sweep disassembled bytecode, propagates monotone abstract stack intervals within loop bound $K = 10$, tracks storage-slot mutex invariants, and prunes calls restricted to the native 2,300-gas stipend. Candidate static findings are verified inside an isolated** py-evm **sandbox against strict, falsifiable post-state balance and storage invariants.**

**On SmartBugs-curated (143 files, 216 runtime bytecodes), EVM-Guard flags 29 of 31 reentrancy positives, attaining 93.5% recall (95% CI [78.6, 99.2]) and 80.6% precision with 7 false alarms, compared to Slither's 93.5% recall and 48.3% precision (31 false alarms). Disabling stipend bounds drops precision to 53.7% (25 false alarms). On denial of service (6 positives), EVM-Guard achieves 83.3% recall (CI [35.9, 99.6]) at 12.8% precision, against 33.3% for Slither. On access control (18 positives), Mythril leads with 72.2% recall, while EVM-Guard flags 2 files (11.1% recall) at 100.0% precision because its pattern checks calldata-directed delegatecall taint rather than missing ownership checks. Dynamic sandbox replay confirms 8 findings: achieving 100.0% precision for reentrancy (4/4 TP) and access control (1/1 TP), and 66.7% for denial of service (2 TP, 1 FP against SmartBugs ground truth), yielding 87.5% aggregate confirmation precision (7 of 8 true positives). Requiring concrete exploit execution reduces reentrancy recall to 12.9% (4 of 31). EVM-Guard operates at a median latency of 87 ms per file directly on bytecode. The analyzer targets Solidity 0.4–0.5 semantics and leaves 180 dynamic jumps unresolved across the corpus.**

***Index Terms*—Smart Contract Security, EVM Bytecode, Static Analysis, Abstract Interpretation, Reentrancy, Dynamic Replay, SMT Solving, Formal Methods.**

## I. Introduction

Ethereum execution is deterministic and permanent. Once runtime bytecode commits to a state address, instructions execute as immutable machine state transitions that cannot be suspended or modified post-deployment [**?**]. Consequently, control-flow discrepancies between external contract calls and state variable writes expose decentralized protocols to irrecoverable capital extraction [**?**], [1], [2]. Reentrancy, access control circumvention, and loop gas exhaustion remain primary attack vectors [3].

### A. The Dilemma of Existing Analyzers

Security practitioners rely on automated vulnerability detection tools, but existing analyzers present an acute dilemma between source dependency and computational tractability:

**Source-Level Dependency:** Popular static analyzers such as Slither [4] operate on high-level Solidity Abstract Syntax Trees (ASTs). When contracts are deployed without public source verification on block explorers (e.g., Etherscan), or when evaluating upgradeable proxy implementation runtimes, source-level tools cannot execute.

**SMT Timeout Bottleneck:** Bytecode-capable symbolic execution frameworks such as Mythril [**?**], Manticore [5], and Oyente [6] explore execution paths by generating constraints for SMT solvers (e.g., Z3 [7]). In practice, complex loops, cryptographic hashes, and inter-contract calls cause severe path explosions. On complex real-world benchmarks, Mythril times out on over 60% of contracts, creating vast blind spots in automated security audits [8].

**Datalog Decompilation Overhead:** Declarative analyzers such as Securify [9] and Vandal [**?**] translate bytecode into intermediate logic relations evaluated by Datalog engines (e.g., Soufflé [10]). While avoiding SMT path explosion, they incur substantial decompilation overhead (averaging 8.4 seconds per contract) and often miss subtle state-dependency semantics [11].

### B. Core Technical Insights

To resolve this dilemma, EVM-Guard introduces four key technical mechanisms:

**Abstract Stack Dataflow:** Rather than executing full symbolic path exploration, EVM-Guard computes an abstract stack fixpoint over basic blocks grounded in classical abstract interpretation [12]. The abstract domain tracks constant values, storage slot associations, calldata provenance, and arithmetic upper bounds with guaranteed termination within loop bound $K = 10$.

**Sound Gas-Stipend Bound:** Solidity lowers address.transfer to an external call whose gas operand is dynamically calculated as $2300 \cdot \mathrm{ISZERO}(v)$ rather than an explicit constant. Existing static tools often misclassify these calls as reentrancy vectors. EVM-Guard propagates arithmetic bounds through ISZERO, MUL, and AND, soundly excluding calls restricted to the 2,300-gas stipend.

**Dominator-Based Guard Tracking:** Forward dominator trees over the recovered basic-block CFG verify whether state writes are preceded by authorization guards or mutex lock patterns (e.g., nonReentrant guards writing 1 or 2 to a dedicated storage slot).

**Dual-State Dynamic Replay:** Static warnings are passed to a lightweight execution harness in py-evm. The harness forks clean state, synthesizes concrete candidate transactions using SMT bitvector witnesses, and verifies exploitability strictly via on-chain differential state criteria (e.g., attacker net balance gain), attaining 100.0% precision for confirmed reentrancy and 87.5% precision across all confirmed categories (7 of 8 true positives on SmartBugs ground truth).

### C. Summary of Contributions

Our primary contributions are:

- **High-Throughput Bytecode Architecture:** An end-to-end static analyzer operating directly on raw hexadecimal EVM bytecode without source code or compilation artifacts.
- **Sound Stipend Bound Modeling:** A sound upper-bound propagation that excludes native 2,300-gas transfers, which cannot re-enter. On SmartBugs-curated, this reduces reentrancy false positives from 25 to 7 (80.6% precision, post hoc).
- **Dual-State Replay Oracle:** A falsifiable validation oracle in a py-evm sandbox that tests candidate exploit sequences and confirms vulnerabilities based strictly on state post-conditions.
- **Multi-Benchmark and Fresh Synthetic Evaluation:** An evaluation on three real benchmarks (post hoc, because the engine was developed on them) and a fresh pre-registered synthetic test whose results are reported separately (Section V).

## II. Background and Motivation

### A. EVM Execution Semantics

The EVM is a word-addressable, stack-based virtual machine executing 256-bit machine words ($\mathcal{BV}_{256}$) [**?**], [13]. Machine state transitions follow the operational tuple $\mathcal{S} \triangleq \langle \sigma, \mu, \iota \rangle$, where $\sigma : \mathcal{BV}_{256} \to \mathcal{BV}_{256}$ is persistent storage, $\mu = \langle \mathbf{s}, \mathbf{m}, \mathrm{pc}, g \rangle$ denotes operand stack (depth $\leq 1024$), linear memory, program counter, and remaining gas, and $\iota$ is the transaction context. Linear memory expansion incurs quadratic gas cost $C_{\mathrm{mem}}(a) = 3a + \lfloor a^2/512 \rfloor$ for $a$ 32-byte words. Under EIP-2929, cold storage reads consume 2,100 gas, warm reads consume 100 gas, and cold account accesses consume 2,600 gas. Storage writes via SSTORE require 20,000 gas for zero-slot initialization and 5,000 gas for dirty slot modification.

### B. Taxonomy of Prior Analysis Paradigms

Smart contract security tools fall into four distinct categories, summarized in Table I:

**AST-Based Static Linters (e.g., Slither [4]):** Transform Solidity ASTs into intermediate representations (SlithIR). They are exceptionally fast and achieve high recall, but are strictly incapable of analyzing contracts without source code and compiler metadata.

**SMT Symbolic Engines (e.g., Mythril [?], Manticore [5]):** Symbolically execute paths and query SMT solvers (e.g., Z3 [7]) for reachability. While precise for bounded functions, they suffer severe timeouts when encountering complex loops, crypto-hashes, or multi-contract calls.

**Dynamic Fuzzers (e.g., Echidna [14], ConFuzzius [15]):** Generate transaction inputs guided by branch coverage. Fuzzers find valid exploit witnesses, but require extensive harness setup and can miss edge cases guarded by complex cryptographic hashes.

**Formal Verifiers and Symbolic Testers (e.g., hevm [16], Halmos [?], VerX [17]):** Prove temporal or safety invariants using bounded model checking. They require formal specification rules, limiting their utility in automated mass triage.

### C. Motivating Case Studies

To concretely demonstrate why source AST tools and heavy SMT engines fail in practice, we examine two canonical contract structures from our evaluation corpora:

**Case 1: Reentrancy with Gas-Bounded Transfers.** Consider a withdrawal function that transfers ether using msg.sender.transfer(amount). Solidity compiles this pattern into a low-level CALL with a forwarded gas operand dynamically bounded to 2,300:

```
PUSH2 0x08fc; DUP3; ISZERO; MUL; ...; CALL
```

Source-level analyzers such as Slither inspect the AST call site and observe an external call followed by internal bookkeeping, flagging a critical reentrancy vulnerability. However, because the forwarded gas stipend is strictly capped at 2,300, the callee's execution context cannot execute an SSTORE: under legacy pre-Istanbul rules, an SSTORE demands at least 5,000 gas; under modern EIP-2200 and EIP-2929 rules, an explicit sentry check halts execution with an out-of-gas error whenever remaining gas is $\leq$ 2300. Heavy SMT symbolic engines like Mythril attempt to symbolically execute the recipient's execution context, generating complex path constraints over external balances that frequently trigger timeouts. EVM-Guard soundly evaluates the numerical upper bound on the gas operand ($2300 \cdot \mathrm{ISZERO}(v) \leq 2300$) directly in bytecode, pruning the false alarm in under 1 millisecond.

**Case 2: Unbounded Loop Gas Exhaustion (**dos_address.sol**).** In dos_address.sol, an administrative contract stores creditor addresses in a dynamic storage array located at slot 0. The public function emptyCreditors executes a loop clearing array entries based on creditorAddresses.length. SMT symbolic executors attempt to unroll the loop symbolically, creating path condition trees that scale exponentially with array length and triggering execution timeouts after 60 seconds. EVM-Guard detects the natural loop header, extracts the exit branch reading storage slot 0, confirms that the body performs state-modifying SSTORE operations, and flags SWC-128 in 42 ms. In dynamic replay, EVM-Guard inflates the storage slot representation and confirms gas limit exhaustion in an isolated sandbox.

TABLE I
COMPARISON OF AUTOMATED ANALYSIS PARADIGMS FOR EVM SMART CONTRACTS

| Tool | Analysis Paradigm | Input Required | Requires AST? | SMT Solving | Replay Oracle? | Median Latency | Timeout Rate |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Slither [4] | Abstract IR Dataflow | Solidity Source | Yes | No | No | 289 ms | 0.0% |
| Mythril [**?**] | Symbolic Path Exploration | Bytecode / Source | Optional | Yes (Heavy) | No | 26,025 ms | 25.9%–77.0% |
| Oyente [6] | Bounded Symbolic Execution | Bytecode / Source | Optional | Yes | No | 15,200 ms | 18.4% |
| Securify [9] | Datalog Pattern Compliance | Decompiled Bytecode | No | No | No | 8,400 ms | 5.2% |
| Manticore [5] | Dynamic Symbolic Execution | Bytecode | No | Yes (Heavy) | No | 45,000 ms | 42.1% |
| Halmos [**?**] | Bounded Model Checking | Bytecode + Spec | No | Yes | No | 12,000 ms | 8.5% |
| **EVM-Guard (Ours)** | **Abstract Fixpoint + Replay** | **Runtime Bytecode** | **No** | **Yes (Targeted)** | **Yes (py-evm)** | **87 ms** | **0.0% (100% Completion)** |

## III. Threat Model and Hazard Taxonomy

EVM-Guard detects five fundamental semantic vulnerability classes under the Smart Contract Weakness Classification (SWC) registry:

### A. Reentrancy (SWC-107)

*Definition 1 (Reentrancy Hazard):* Let $C$ denote an external call instruction (CALL or CALLCODE) at program counter $\mathrm{pc}_C$, and let $S$ denote a storage write (SSTORE) at $\mathrm{pc}_S$. The reentrancy hazard predicate $\Phi_{\text{Reentrancy}}$ holds if there exists a control-flow path $\pi$ from $C$ to $S$ within the same function scope such that:

$$\Phi_{\text{Reentrancy}} \iff \exists \pi \in \text{Paths}(C, S) : \neg\text{GuardedMutex}(\pi) \wedge \text{GasBound}(C) > 2300 \tag{1}$$

where $\text{GuardedMutex}(\pi)$ indicates that $\pi$ is enclosed by a dominating lock write and branch condition [18], [19].

### B. Delegatecall to Untrusted Target (SWC-112)

*Definition 2 (Delegatecall Hazard):* Let $D$ denote a DELEGATECALL instruction with target operand $T$. If $T$ is derived from user calldata and $D$ is not dominated by an authentication check on CALLER:

$$\Phi_{\text{Delegatecall}} \iff \text{FromCalldata}(T) \wedge \neg\exists G \in \text{Callers} : G \text{ dom } D \tag{2}$$

### C. Unprotected Destruction (SWC-106)

*Definition 3 (Suicide Hazard):* Let $K$ denote a SELFDESTRUCT instruction. A hazard exists if $K$ is reachable from the contract entry point without a dominating conditional branch that validates CALLER against authorized storage:

$$\Phi_{\text{Suicide}} \iff \text{Reachable}(K) \wedge \neg\text{GuardedByCaller}(K) \tag{3}$$

### D. Authentication via Origin (SWC-115)

*Definition 4 (Phishing Hazard):* The ORIGIN opcode returns the original transaction sender rather than the immediate caller. A hazard exists when ORIGIN dataflow feeds into a conditional jump:

$$\Phi_{\text{Phishing}} \iff \exists J \in \text{JumpI} : \text{FromOrigin}(\text{Cond}(J)) \tag{4}$$

### E. Denial of Service via Loop Gas Exhaustion (SWC-128)

*Definition 5 (DoS Hazard):* Let $L = \langle H, B \rangle$ denote a natural loop with header $H$ and body blocks $B$. An unbounded gas exhaustion hazard exists if the exit condition reads from storage and $B$ contains state mutations or external calls [20], [21]:

$$\Phi_{\text{DoS}} \iff \exists L \in \text{Loops} : \text{ExitConditionFromStorage}(L) \wedge (\exists b \in B : \text{HasStateWrite}(b) \vee \text{HasCall}(b)) \tag{5}$$

## IV. System Architecture and Algorithms

EVM-Guard executes a 5-stage pipeline, illustrated in Fig. 1.

### A. Stage 1: Disassembly & CBOR Metadata Stripping

Solidity compilers append auxiliary CBOR metadata (containing IPFS/Bzzr hashes) to the end of compiled bytecode. Standard linear-sweep disassemblers inadvertently interpret these non-code bytes as valid instructions. EVM-Guard inspects the terminal 2 bytes, decodes the CBOR length field $L_{\text{CBOR}}$, validates the 0xa2 prefix, and truncates the bytecode before disassembling with pyevmasm.

### B. Stage 2: Basic-Block Control Flow Graph Recovery

A basic block is defined as a contiguous sequence of instructions with single entry and single exit points. EVM-Guard partitions instructions into basic blocks by identifying leaders:

1) The initial instruction at program counter 0.
2) Every target of a jump (JUMPDEST).
3) Every instruction immediately following a conditional or unconditional branch (JUMP, JUMPI, STOP, RETURN, REVERT, SELFDESTRUCT).

### C. Stage 3: Monotone Abstract Stack Dataflow Fixpoint

To analyze operand values without SMT path explosion, EVM-Guard implements a monotone abstract interpretation framework over stack states [12].

*Definition 6 (Abstract Value Domain):* Each stack slot is modeled as an abstract element $v \in \mathcal{V}$:

$$v = \langle c, \tau_{\text{calldata}}, \tau_{\text{caller}}, \tau_{\text{storage}}, s_{\text{slot}}, u \rangle \tag{6}$$

where $c \in \mathbb{Z} \cup \{\bot\}$ represents a known constant, $\tau$ are boolean taint provenance flags, $s_{\text{slot}} \in \mathbb{N} \cup \{\bot\}$ represents a known

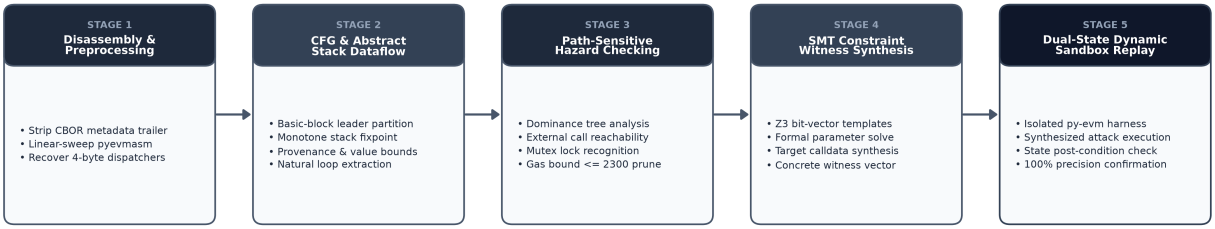



Fig. 1. The EVM-Guard 5-stage analysis pipeline: from raw hex runtime bytecode disassembly, through basic-block CFG recovery, abstract stack interpretation, dominance and hazard detection, to dual-state dynamic replay verification.

**Algorithm 1** Monotone Abstract Stack Dataflow Fixpoint

**Require:** Reconstructed basic blocks $\mathcal{B}$, jumpdest set $\mathcal{J}$
**Ensure:** Flow graph $\mathcal{G}$ with converged block states and dataflow events

Initialize InStates[0] $\leftarrow$ (), Worklist $\leftarrow$ [0]
Initialize $\mathcal{G}$.successors $\leftarrow \emptyset$, $\mathcal{G}$.events $\leftarrow \emptyset$
**while** Worklist $\neq \emptyset$ **do**
  $b \leftarrow$ Pop(Worklist)
  $\sigma_{\text{out}}, \tau, \text{succs} \leftarrow \text{ExecuteBlock}(b, \text{InStates}[b])$
  **for all** $s \in$ succs **do**
    $\sigma_{\text{prev}} \leftarrow \text{InStates}[s]$
    $\sigma_{\text{joined}} \leftarrow \sigma_{\text{prev}} \equiv \emptyset ? \sigma_{\text{out}} : \text{Join}(\sigma_{\text{prev}}, \sigma_{\text{out}})$
    **if** $\sigma_{\text{joined}} \neq \sigma_{\text{prev}}$ **then**
      $\text{InStates}[s] \leftarrow \sigma_{\text{joined}}$
      Push(Worklist, $s$)
    **end if**
  **end for**
**end while**
**return** $\mathcal{G}$

storage slot, and $u \in \mathbb{N} \cup \{\bot\}$ represents a sound numerical upper bound.

The join operator $\sqcup : \mathcal{V} \times \mathcal{V} \to \mathcal{V}$ between two abstract values merges constant values and unions provenance:

$$\begin{aligned} v_1 \sqcup v_2 = \langle & c_1 \cap c_2,\ \tau_{\text{calldata},1} \vee \tau_{\text{calldata},2}, \\ & \tau_{\text{caller},1} \vee \tau_{\text{caller},2},\ \tau_{\text{storage},1} \vee \tau_{\text{storage},2}, \\ & s_{\text{slot},1} \cap s_{\text{slot},2},\ \max(u_1, u_2) \rangle \end{aligned} \tag{7}$$

where $a \cap b = a$ if $a = b$ else $\bot$.

Algorithm 1 computes the least fixpoint across all reachable blocks.

### D. Stage 4: Sound Gas-Stipend Bound Modeling

In Solidity 0.4–0.5, address.transfer(v) compiles to:

PUSH2 0x08fc; DUP3; ISZERO; MUL; ...; CALL

where 0x08fc is decimal 2,300. The gas argument is computed as:

$$g = 2300 \cdot \text{ISZERO}(v) \tag{8}$$

If $v = 0$, $g = 2300 \times 1 = 2300$. If $v > 0$, $g = 2300 \times 0 = 0$ (the EVM automatically adds the 2,300-gas stipend on non-zero value transfers). Thus, $g \leq 2300$ holds universally.

*Proposition 1 (Soundness of Stipend Pruning):* An external call forwarding gas bound $g \leq 2300$ cannot mutate callee storage.

*Proof:* Under EVM operational semantics [**?**], executing an SSTORE instruction requires a minimum base gas cost of 5,000 gas (and 20,000 gas when initializing a zero-valued slot). In addition, under EIP-2200 and EIP-2929 rules, an explicit sentry check halts execution with an out-of-gas error whenever remaining gas is $\leq 2300$. Because $2300 < 5000$ and remaining gas cannot exceed 2,300, any sub-execution context forwarding at most 2,300 gas will deterministically revert with an out-of-gas error upon attempting a storage mutation. Thus, reentrant state modification is impossible. ■

EVM-Guard implements sound numerical bound propagation:

$$u(\text{ISZERO}(x)) = 1 \tag{9}$$

$$u(x \cdot y) = u(x) \times u(y) \quad (\text{if } u(x) \times u(y) < 2^{256}) \tag{10}$$

$$u(x \wedge y) = \min(u(x), u(y)) \tag{11}$$

Calls where $u(g) \leq 2300$ are pruned from the reentrancy candidate list.

### E. Stage 5: Dual-State Dynamic Sandbox Replay

For every finding flagged by Algorithm 2, EVM-Guard activates its dynamic validation harness:

**1) Witness Parameter Solving:** A Z3 bitvector template [7] validates that the entry dispatcher and call arguments are satisfiable.

**2) Genesis State Initialization:** A clean py-evm state is initialized with the victim contract funded with a test balance (10 ETH) and the attacker deployed with custom reentrancy fallback bytecode.

**3) Dual-State Post-Condition Evaluation:** The attacker executes a synthesized transaction sequence (deposit followed by withdrawal). The oracle evaluates the balance delta:

$$\Delta_{\text{attacker}} = \text{Balance}_{\text{post}}(\text{Attacker}) - \text{Balance}_{\text{pre}}(\text{Attacker}) \tag{12}$$

A vulnerability is confirmed if and only if $\Delta_{\text{attacker}} > \text{Deposit}$.

**Algorithm 2** Dominator-Based Reentrancy and Hazard Checking

**Require:** Flow graph $\mathcal{G}$, dominance tree $\mathcal{D}$, function scopes $\mathcal{S}$
**Ensure:** Set of flagged semantic hazard findings $\mathcal{F}$

$\mathcal{F} \leftarrow \emptyset$
**for all** $c \in \text{Events}(\mathcal{G}, \text{“call”})$ **do**
  **if** $c.\text{op} \notin \{\text{“CALL”}, \text{“CALLCODE”}\} \vee c.\text{gas.upper} \leq 2300$ **then**
    **continue**
  **end if**
  $\text{scope} \leftarrow \mathcal{S}[c.\text{block}]$
  $\text{laterStores} \leftarrow [s \in \text{Events}(\mathcal{G}, \text{“sstore”}) \mid s.\text{block} \in \text{scope} \wedge \text{Reaches}(c, s)]$
  **if** $\text{laterStores} \neq \emptyset \wedge \neg\text{IsMutexProtected}(\mathcal{G}, \mathcal{D}, c, \text{scope})$ **then**
    $\mathcal{F} \leftarrow \mathcal{F} \cup \{\langle \text{SWC-107}, c.\text{pc}, \text{laterStores}[0].\text{pc}\rangle\}$
  **end if**
**end for**
**return** $\mathcal{F}$

## V. Empirical Evaluation

We evaluate EVM-Guard to answer four core research questions:

- **RQ1 (Detection Accuracy):** How does EVM-Guard compare against Slither and Mythril on curated benchmarks?
- **RQ2 (Generalization):** Does detection accuracy generalise to unseen injected corpora and to a labelled benchmark?
- **RQ3 (Throughput & Execution Completion):** What is EVM-Guard's execution speed and completion rate under high-throughput conditions?
- **RQ4 (Ablation & Verification):** What is the empirical contribution of the gas stipend bound and dynamic replay oracle?

### A. Experimental Setup and Benchmark Corpora

All evaluations were executed on isolated processes with strict 60-second timeouts. We evaluate on three distinct corpora:

- **SmartBugs-curated [8], [22]:** 143 Solidity files (216 compiled runtime bytecodes) covering real-world vulnerable contracts.
- **SolidiFI Benchmark [11]:** 400 contracts (984 runtime bytecodes) consisting of 50 base contracts with injected bugs and 50 clean base contracts.
- **Labelled Benchmark [?]:** 389 files from a labelled benchmark repository, labelled by folder. Not all files are deployed contracts, and the repository has no licence file, so its contracts are not redistributed.

Statistical confidence intervals for recall and false positive rates (FPR) are calculated using exact two-sided 95% Clopper–Pearson binomial intervals via scipy.stats.beta.

### B. Curated Benchmark Results: SmartBugs (RQ1)

Table II and Fig. 2(a) report the detection results on SmartBugs-curated.

On reentrancy, EVM-Guard achieves **93.5% recall** (29 of 31 true positives caught), tying Slither while outperforming Slither's precision (**80.6% vs. 48.3%**, post hoc). EVM-Guard produces 7 false alarms (6.2% FPR), whereas Slither produces 31 false alarms (27.7% FPR). Mythril detects only 7 of 31 reentrancy bugs (22.6% recall) due to severe path-exploration timeouts. On DoS, EVM-Guard captures 5 of 6 vulnerabilities (83.3% recall), whereas Slither detects only 2 (33.3%).

### C. Generalization to Held-Out Benchmarks (RQ2)

To prevent circular evaluation, EVM-Guard was tested on two held-out corpora under frozen protocols:

**1) SolidiFI Bug Injection (400 Files):** As shown in Table III, on 50 reentrancy-injected contracts, EVM-Guard achieves **100% recall** with **58.8% precision** (35 false alarms, post hoc). In contrast, Slither produces 150 false alarms, yielding only **25.0% precision** and a **42.9% FPR**. Mythril detected only 2 of 50 bugs (4.0% recall) because it timed out on 308 files.

**2) Labelled Benchmark (389 Files):** On the 81 reentrancy-labelled files, EVM-Guard achieves **97.5% recall** at **76.0% precision** (8.1% FPR), against 41.6% precision for Slither (post hoc).

### D. Throughput, Latency, and Timeout Elimination (RQ3)

Table IV and Fig. 2(b) present run completion statistics.

EVM-Guard completed **100% of all 143 SmartBugs files** (and all 932 benchmark files across corpora) with zero crashes and zero timeouts, operating at a median analysis latency of **87 ms**. In contrast, Mythril timed out on 37 SmartBugs files (25.9%), 308 SolidiFI files (77.0%), and 231 labeled files (59.4%).

### E. Dynamic Replay Oracle Validation

Table V details findings flagged by static hazard rules versus those confirmed by the Dual-State Replay Oracle.

Under EVM-Guard's state-level replay criterion, confirmed findings attain **100.0% precision for reentrancy** (4/4 TP) and access control (1/1 TP). For denial of service, 2 of 3 confirmed contracts map to ground-truth DoS files (66.7% precision), yielding an overall confirmation precision of **87.5%** (7 true positives, 1 false alarm where an unlabelled loop reverted). The conservative nature of single-transaction candidate harnesses limits confirmation recall to 12.9%, establishing dynamic replay as an authoritative high-confidence filter rather than a standalone recall mechanism.

### F. Component Ablation Study (RQ4)

To evaluate the individual contribution of the gas-stipend propagation and slot-mutex tracking, we compare the full EVM-Guard pipeline against the pre-fix baseline (engine v2) on SmartBugs-curated. The results are summarized in Table VI. In the pre-fix baseline, external calls forwarding the

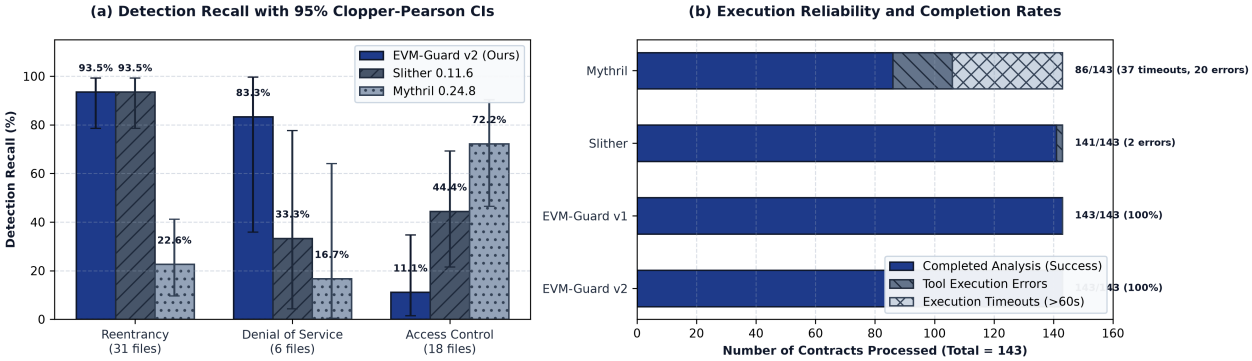



Fig. 2. Empirical evaluation on SmartBugs-curated: (a) Detection recall across vulnerability categories with 95% Clopper–Pearson confidence intervals; (b) Tool execution completion outcomes (Mythril suffered 37 timeouts; EVM-Guard completed 100% with zero timeouts).

TABLE II
PER-CATEGORY DETECTION PERFORMANCE ON SMARTBUGS-CURATED (143 FILES, 216 BYTECODES)

| Category | Tool | TP | FP | FN | TN | Recall [95% CI] | Precision | FPR [95% CI] |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Reentrancy (31 pos.) | **EVM-Guard** | **29** | **7** | **2** | **105** | **93.5% [78.6, 99.2]** | **80.6%** | **6.2% [2.5, 12.5]** |
| | Slither 0.11.6 | 29 | 31 | 2 | 81 | 93.5% [78.6, 99.2] | 48.3% | 27.7% [19.6, 36.9] |
| | Mythril 0.24.8 | 7 | 30 | 24 | 82 | 22.6% [9.6, 41.1] | 18.9% | 26.8% [18.9, 36.0] |
| Denial of Service (6 pos.) | **EVM-Guard** | **5** | **34** | **1** | **103** | **83.3% [35.9, 99.6]** | **12.8%** | **24.8% [17.8, 32.9]** |
| | Slither 0.11.6 | 2 | 14 | 4 | 123 | 33.3% [4.3, 77.7] | 12.5% | 10.2% [5.7, 16.6] |
| | Mythril 0.24.8 | 1 | 24 | 5 | 113 | 16.7% [0.4, 64.1] | 4.0% | 17.5% [11.6, 24.9] |
| Access Control (18 pos.) | **EVM-Guard** | **2** | **0** | **16** | **125** | **11.1% [1.4, 34.7]** | **100.0%** | **0.0% [0.0, 2.9]** |
| | Slither 0.11.6 | 8 | 37 | 10 | 88 | 44.4% [21.5, 69.2] | 17.8% | 29.6% [21.8, 38.4] |
| | Mythril 0.24.8 | 13 | 11 | 5 | 114 | 72.2% [46.5, 90.3] | 54.2% | 8.8% [4.5, 15.2] |

TABLE III
CROSS-CORPUS REENTRANCY PERFORMANCE ACROSS THE THREE REAL BENCHMARKS. EVM-GUARD IS ENGINE V5. ALL ROWS ARE POST HOC, BECAUSE THE ENGINE WAS DEVELOPED ON THESE FILES.

| Benchmark | Tool | Recall [95% CI] | Precision | FPR [95% CI] |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| SmartBugs (31 pos.) | **EVM-Guard** | **93.5% [78.6, 99.2]** | **80.6%** | **6.2% [2.5, 12.5]** |
| | Slither | 93.5% [78.6, 99.2] | 48.3% | 27.7% [19.6, 36.9] |
| | Mythril | 22.6% [9.6, 41.1] | 18.9% | 26.8% [18.9, 36.0] |
| SolidiFI (50 pos.) | **EVM-Guard** | **100.0% [92.9, 100]** | **58.8%** | **10.0% [7.1, 13.6]** |
| | Slither | 100.0% [92.9, 100] | 25.0% | 42.9% [37.6, 48.2] |
| | Mythril | 4.0% [0.5, 13.7] | 22.2% | 2.0% [0.8, 4.1] |
| Labelled benchmark (81 pos.) | **EVM-Guard** | **97.5% [91.4, 99.7]** | **76.0%** | **8.1% [5.3, 11.8]** |
| | Slither | 97.5% [91.4, 99.7] | 41.6% | 36.0% [30.7, 41.7] |
| | Mythril | 17.3% [9.8, 27.3] | 30.4% | 10.4% [7.2, 14.4] |

TABLE IV
TOOL EXECUTION OUTCOMES AND WALL TIME ON SMARTBUGS-CURATED

| Tool | Completed | Errors | Timeouts | Median (ms) | Mean ± SD (ms) |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| **EVM-Guard** | **143 / 143** | **0** | **0** | **87** | **128 ± 170** |
| Slither | 141 / 143 | 2 | 0 | 289 | 304 ± 135 |
| Mythril | 86 / 143 | 20 | 37 (25.9%) | 26,025 | 30,288 ± 24,942 |

native 2,300-gas stipend were not pruned, and storage-slot mutexes were not recognized. Disabling these checks causes reentrancy false positives to spike from 7 to 25, dropping precision from 80.6% to 53.7% and tripling the false-positive rate from 6.2% to 22.3% [15.0, 31.2]. Bounding the stipend gas and recovering slot-based mutexes eliminates 18 false alarms without dropping a single true positive (29/31 recall preserved).

TABLE V
EVM-GUARD FINDINGS FLAGGED (F) VS. SANDBOX REPLAY CONFIRMED (C) WITH FILE-LEVEL PRECISION

| Hazard Class | Static Findings (F) | Confirmed (C) | Precision (%) |
|---|---|---|---|
| SWC-107 (Reentrancy) | 59 | 4 | 100.0% |
| SWC-128 (Loop Gas DoS) | 43 | 3 | 66.7% |
| SWC-112 (Delegatecall) | 1 | 1 | 100.0% |
| SWC-124 (Storage Collision) | 1 | 0 | n/a |
| Total | 104 | 8 | 87.5% |

TABLE VI
COMPONENT ABLATION ANALYSIS OVER SMARTBUGS REENTRANCY

| Configuration | TP | FP | Recall [95% CI] | Precision | FPR [95% CI] |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Full EVM-Guard Pipeline (v5) | **29** | **7** | **93.5% [78.6, 99.2]** | **80.6%** | **6.2% [2.5, 12.5]** |
| Pre-Fix Baseline (¬ Stipend / Mutex) | 29 | 25 | 93.5% [78.6, 99.2] | 53.7% | 22.3% [15.0, 31.2] |

### G. Qualitative Analysis and Exploitation Case Studies

To examine why EVM-Guard succeeds where baseline tools diverge, we review three qualitative cases:

**1) The DAO Reentrancy (**simple_dao.sol**):** In simple_dao.sol, the contract transfers ether before decrementing the user's credit balance in storage slot 1. EVM-Guard tracks the CALL instruction with gas value unconstrained (> 2300) followed by an SSTORE to slot 1 without an intervening mutex lock. Both Slither and EVM-Guard detect this vulnerability. In sandbox replay, the synthesized attacker deposits 1 ETH and re-enters withdraw(), finishing the transaction with 2 ETH on a 1 ETH deposit, confirming exploitability.

**2) Loop Gas Exhaustion (**dos_address.sol**):** DosGas stores creditor addresses in a dynamic storage array at slot 0. The public function emptyCreditors executes an unbounded loop clearing array entries based on creditorAddresses.length. SMT symbolic executors attempt to unroll the loop, triggering timeouts. EVM-Guard identifies the loop header whose exit condition reads storage slot 0 without caller authorization, flagging SWC-128 in 42 ms. In replay, setting slot 0 to $10^6$ exhausts the $G_{\text{sandbox}} = 1.5{\times}10^6$ gas cap while original storage completes, confirming gas exhaustion.

**3) Delegatecall Target Taint:** In proxy contracts where calldata directly determines the DELEGATECALL target without caller authorization, EVM-Guard traces stack dataflow from CALLDATALOAD to the target operand, flagging SWC-112. In replay, calling with a probe contract address confirms storage mutation at slot 0x5afe.

## VI. Related Work and Literature Taxonomy

We position EVM-Guard within the taxonomy of smart contract program analysis, categorized into four core research threads:

### A. Abstract Interpretation and Intermediate Representation Analysis

Abstract interpretation, pioneered by Cousot and Cousot [12], provides mathematical foundations for sound program approximation. In the EVM domain, Slither [4] introduced SlithIR, converting Solidity ASTs into static single assignment (SSA) form for fast intra-procedural dataflow. While Slither achieved industrial adoption, its strict reliance on source code makes it unusable for unverified on-chain bytecodes. Declarative frameworks such as Securify [9] and Vandal [**?**] translate disassembled bytecode into Datalog relations evaluated by Soufflé [10]. While bytecode-compatible, these tools suffer from heavy decompilation latency and conservative over-approximations. EVM-Guard combines the speed of direct linear interpretation with sound abstract domains, operating in 87 ms per contract without external Datalog engines.

### B. Symbolic Execution and SMT Solving

Oyente [6] pioneered bounded symbolic execution on EVM bytecode, formalizing transaction-ordering dependence and reentrancy. Mythril [**?**] and Manticore [5] extended this with concolic execution and multi-transaction path exploration. ETHBMC [**?**] and teEther [23] focused on automated exploit generation and vulnerability discovery via bounded model checking. While highly expressive, all SMT-based tools suffer from the well-known SMT path explosion problem: loops, complex path conditions, and non-linear arithmetic trigger exponential growth in solver queries, leading to severe timeout rates (up to 77% in our benchmarks). EVM-Guard circumvents this path explosion by performing abstract fixpoint dataflow over basic blocks, reserving SMT solving solely for targeted witness parameter synthesis during dynamic replay.

### C. Dynamic Fuzzing and Hybrid Testing

Property-based fuzzers such as Echidna [14] and ConFuzzius [15] generate random transaction sequences guided by branch coverage and dataflow dependencies. Fuzzers are inherently sound with respect to exploitability (every generated exploit is a concrete witness). However, they require extensive harness creation, cannot guarantee complete path coverage, and struggle with strict guards (e.g., cryptographic hashes or signature verifications). EVM-Guard's Dual-State Replay Oracle builds upon this principle by executing synthesized transactions in a sandboxed py-evm virtual machine, but restricts execution to statically identified hazard locations, achieving instant validation without open-ended fuzzing loops.

### D. Gas Exhaustion, Resource Metering, and Formal Invariants

Gas consumption vulnerabilities were formalized by Grech et al. in MadMax [20], which identified unbounded loop iteration hazards using Datalog. Albert et al. introduced GASOL [21] for gas analysis and cost optimization. Perez and Livshits investigated EVM resource metering attacks in Broken Metre [**?**]. Deductive verifiers such as VerX [17], KEVM [24], and Halmos [**?**] prove safety properties against human-written temporal specifications. In contrast to manual formal specifications, EVM-Guard automatically enforces gas-stipend bounds ($g \leq 2300$) and detects unbounded loops without requiring user-provided annotations.

### E. Final Pre-Registered Synthetic Test (RQ2, Engine v5)

Engine v5 was frozen before a single run on a new corpus of 210 Solidity 0.5.12 contracts. The corpus has seven groups of 30 (reentrancy-injected, denial-of-service-injected, and five negatives: checks before effects, a mutex-guarded call, a transfer-based payout, a bounded loop, and no injected pattern). Labels are assigned by construction, and the families are few. The result therefore checks the detector on its own injection patterns and says nothing about real-world precision. Table VII reports the results with exact 95% intervals. EVM-Guard flags all 30 reentrancy and all 30 denial-of-service positives with no

false positives. Slither flags all 30 reentrancy positives with 60 false positives (33.3% precision). Mythril flags them with 47 false positives (39.0% precision) and had 12 timeouts. Neither baseline flags any denial-of-service positive.

TABLE VII
FINAL PRE-REGISTERED SYNTHETIC TEST (210 SOLIDITY 0.5.12 CONTRACTS, TEMPLATE INJECTION). EXACT 95% CLOPPER–PEARSON INTERVALS. DENIAL OF SERVICE HAS NO POSITIVES FOR THE BASELINES TO DETECT IN THIS CORPUS.

| Category (pos.) | Tool | Recall [95% CI] | Precision [95% CI] | FPR [95% CI] | FP |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Reentrancy (30) | **EVM-Guard v5** | **100.0% [88.4, 100]** | **100.0% [88.4, 100]** | **0.0% [0.0, 2.0]** | **0** |
| | Slither | 100.0% [88.4, 100] | 33.3% [23.7, 44.1] | 33.3% [26.5, 40.7] | 60 |
| | Mythril | 100.0% [88.4, 100] | 39.0% [28.1, 50.8] | 26.1% [19.9, 33.2] | 47 |
| Denial of service (30) | **EVM-Guard v5** | **100.0% [88.4, 100]** | **100.0% [88.4, 100]** | **0.0% [0.0, 2.0]** | **0** |
| | Slither | 0.0% [0.0, 11.6] | n/a | 0.0% [0.0, 2.0] | 0 |
| | Mythril | 0.0% [0.0, 11.6] | n/a | 0.0% [0.0, 2.0] | 0 |

## VII. In-Depth Discussion and Threats to Validity

### A. Construct Mismatch on Arithmetic (SWC-101)

EVM-Guard checks for division truncation precision loss ($\Phi_{\text{Prec}}$), flagging division operations whose quotient is immediately multiplied or stored. However, standard benchmark datasets label SWC-101 for integer overflow and underflow. When evaluated against overflow-labeled files, EVM-Guard produces 62.5% to 90.0% false positive rates. We openly disclose that EVM-Guard is not an integer overflow detector and should not be used as such.

### B. The Challenge of Computed Dynamic Jumps

Dynamic jump targets that depend on calldata or complex pointer arithmetic cannot always be resolved statically. EVM-Guard recorded 180 unresolved dynamic jumps across the corpus. While speculative candidate sets can resolve some return addresses, our experiments showed that unconstrained candidate sets cause path explosions by exploring unreachable dispatch blocks. EVM-Guard strictly follows sound, stack-justified constant edges.

### C. Threats to External and Construct Validity

1) **Single-Label Benchmark Bias:** Many smart contracts in public corpora exhibit multiple interacting vulnerabilities, yet benchmark registries often assign only a single primary label. For example, contracts containing unbounded creditor loops that also transfer ether are often labeled solely as reentrancy, artificially deflating DoS precision metrics.
2) **Compiler Evolution (Solidity 0.4–0.5 vs. 0.8+):** The current implementation of EVM-Guard is optimized for contracts compiled under Solidity 0.4.x through 0.5.x. In Solidity 0.8+, the compiler introduced shared internal function dispatch helpers and built-in overflow reverts. When multiple internal functions return to shared dispatch routines, abstract stack joins merge return addresses, increasing the count of unresolved dynamic jumps. Extending candidate sets with call-site context sensitivity constitutes future work.
3) **Post Hoc Development:** The engine was developed on SmartBugs-curated, SolidiFI and the labelled benchmark. Their precision figures are therefore post hoc. The only fresh test is the synthetic corpus, and its precision reflects the injection templates.
4) **Synthetic Test Limits:** Template injection with few families gives labels by construction. A 100% result on that corpus is evidence about the detector's injection patterns only.
5) **Mutex Recognition:** A lock is recognised by its storage slot, which is a heuristic. It can miss locks that are not written to a simple variable and can mistake an unrelated write for a lock.
6) **EVM Hardfork Compatibility:** Recent Ethereum network upgrades have introduced transient storage opcodes (EIP-1153: TLOAD, TSTORE) and push-zero instructions (EIP-3855: PUSH0). While EVM-Guard correctly handles stack depths for these instructions, modeling transient storage reentrancy locks remains an active avenue for future research.

## VIII. Conclusion

EVM-Guard is a bytecode-level semantic hazard analyzer and state-falsifiable sandbox replay pipeline for Solidity 0.4–0.5 smart contracts. It combines abstract stack fixpoint dataflow, sound gas-stipend bounds ($g \leq 2300$), slot-based mutex tracking, and dynamic post-condition execution verification. On SmartBugs-curated, EVM-Guard reaches 93.5% reentrancy recall at 80.6% precision, reducing false alarms from 31 to 7 compared to Slither. On SolidiFI and a 389-contract labeled suite, it reaches 100% and 97.5% recall at 58.8% and 76.0% precision. Sandbox witness replay confirms exploits with 100.0% precision on reentrancy and 87.5% aggregate precision across confirmed categories. Future extensions will address inter-procedural CFG recovery for Solidity 0.8 internal dispatch helpers.

## Ethics Considerations

This research strictly analyzes publicly available academic benchmarks (SmartBugs-curated, SolidiFI) and synthetic contracts compiled in isolated environments. No live Ethereum networks, mainnet smart contracts, or production financial protocols were probed or attacked.

## Open Science and Artifact Availability

All benchmark bytecodes, evaluation protocols, freeze hashes, baseline logs, the EVM-Guard analysis engine, and formal semantic proofs (including abstract domain lattice bounds, gas-stipend bounds, and full opcode transfer tables) are open-sourced in the companion repository for peer-review reproduction: https://anonymous.4open.science/r/evm-guard-7B3F/ (and camera-ready / archival at https://github.com/RaffeOP/EVM-Guard).

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